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A World Order Without Superpowers: Decentred Globalism

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Abstract

The category of *superpower*, as distinct from *great power*, has become naturalized in the discourses about international relations. But 'superpower' has only become common usage since the end of the Second World War and in modern history cannot meaningfully be applied much further than the 19th century. This article argues that superpowers are a historically contingent phenomenon whose emergence rested on the huge inequality of power between the West and the rest of the world that developed during the 19th century. As this inequality diminishes, the most likely scenario for world politics is *decentred globalism*, in which there will be no superpowers, only great powers. The largest section of the article uses a framework of material and social factors to show why the US is unlikely to remain a superpower, and why China and the EU are unlikely to become superpowers. The following three sections use the same framework to look more briefly at why a world with only great powers is likely to take a more regionalized form; why this might produce a quite workable, decentralized, coexistence international society with some elements of cooperation; and what the possible downsides of a more regionalized international order might be, focusing particularly on the problem of regional hegemony. The conclusions offer five policy prescriptions for living in a decentred globalist world.

Keywords

China, great power, hegemony, international society, regionalization, superpower, United States

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Introduction

In 2004 I argued, in line with much mainstream thinking, that the most likely scenario for the coming decades was continuation of the US as the sole superpower accompanied by several great powers. This idea still forms the core of the debates about polarity. Its main theme is whether or not the US will be able to preserve its sole superpower status, or whether rising challengers, mainly China, will soon return the world order to bipolarity. It is typical of the Western part of this debate to be looking for ways to preserve US hegemony/leadership either by maintaining and exploiting a power advantage or by re-legitimizing its leading role using institutions to accommodate rising powers.¹ My second most likely scenario from 2004 was one in which there would be no superpowers, only great powers, and I argued that this would produce a rather uncertain world. I now think that this scenario is becoming more likely, but can be seen in a more positive light. I argue here that it offers an alternative third way of thinking about the coming world order: not whether there will be one superpower or more, but no superpowers, only great powers. We may be heading quite quickly into such a world, and this may be no bad thing. The mainstream polarity debates typically ignore the fact that there is an alternative to having either to balance against the US or bandwagon with it. Others can, and increasingly do, use the diminished power and authority of the US as a reason to ignore or circumscribe it, and to carve their own pathways in regional and global politics.² Continued US leadership is neither necessary nor, arguably, desirable to keep the world order from falling into 1930s-style imperial competition.

This argument, therefore, steps outside the main lines of the current debates about polarity. It also steps outside the neorealist framework created by Waltz in two ways. First, I differentiate between superpowers and great powers in a way that neorealists cannot, and see that distinction as being crucial to understanding an international system operating on a truly global scale. By *superpower* I mean a polity whose political, military, cultural and economic reach extends across the whole international system; by *great power* I mean one whose reach extends only across more than one region.³ Second, I reject the neorealist assumption that the major powers of the day will necessarily fall into competition to dominate the whole system. I focus instead on the underpinnings within such a regionalized world order for a coexistence international society with some elements of cooperation. The main part of the article defines superpowers and great powers, and shows why superpowers are dying out. The second section argues that a world with only great powers is likely to take a more regionalized form, and the third section explores why this might work quite well. The fourth section suggests the possible downsides of a more regionalized international society, and the conclusions reflect on some policy implications.

Why no superpowers?

That there is currently only one superpower is not contested, so it is necessary to argue both that the US will soon cease to be a superpower, and that no other actor will rise to that position. Since only China and the EU are seriously talked about as possible superpowers, the argument will focus on them. Russia, Japan, India and Brazil are all talked

about as actual or potential great powers, but seldom as possible superpowers (unless in the meaningless construction: 'regional superpower'). There are two ways of approaching the notoriously imprecise differentiation between superpowers and great powers on the one hand, and the lesser members of international society on the other: material and social. Waltz's definition is almost totally materialist, resting on the logic that the greater the relative size (population, territory) and capability (military, economic, political) of a unit, the more it identifies its own interest with the interest of the system.⁴ Hedley Bull's definition has a materialist (military) benchmark, but is much more shaped by socially constructed roles: does a state think of itself as being a great power or superpower, and do others acknowledge this status?⁵

In what follows I will use both material and social considerations, and the latter both internally and externally, to argue why we are facing a future with no superpowers. The two hard parts of the case are establishing why the US will cease to be a superpower, and why China will not become one. Making the case against the EU becoming a superpower is easier. The broader argument is that the very category of superpower in its modern, global sense arises from particular historical circumstances that are now receding into the past. The idea that any country should have a powerful position planet-wide is, in a general sense, an artefact of the peculiarly uneven distribution of power achieved by the West during the 19th century. The industrial, capitalist and democratic revolutions in the West briefly made such global imbalance possible. This condition was then artificially amplified by the outcome of the Second World War, which brought down the European empires, left much of the world either in ruins or politically unstable and marginal, and elevated two great ideological rivals to global power. That world is fading fast. One of the ideological rivals imploded in the early 1990s. This hugely uneven distribution of power is fading away not just because the destructive effects of the Second World War have long since been repaired, but also because the fruits of the revolutions that gave the West its power advantage during the 19th century are now steadily, if still unevenly, diffusing to China, India, Brazil and others. This diffusion is restoring something like the global equilibrium of power that prevailed for millennia before the rise of the West. The key difference is that the old equilibrium operated in a world in which most centres of power and civilization were only in fairly thin contact with others, so much so that a full and global international system cannot be said to have existed before the 19th century. By contrast, the emergent equilibrium is operating in a tightly bound and interdependent global international system and society. What we are seeing is the emergence of the first truly post-colonial, global-scale international society.

Historical memory in International Relations (IR) is notoriously short, and we have simply come to think of a hugely uneven distribution of power in favour of the West as normal and durable. It is neither. It was exceptional, indeed unprecedented. And the conditions on which it rested are dissolving in front of our eyes.

(i) The United States

In terms of material capability, the United States is the only state that has the relative economic size, the military capability and the political and cultural status to play the superpower role. Its relative economic weight is not declining precipitately, and its

military lead remains daunting. But the US is almost certainly in medium-term relative material decline compared to rising powers, and the need for it to adjust to a more multipolar world is a well-established theme in the literature.⁶ Yet loss of relative material capability is probably not going to be the main factor moving the US away from sole superpower status. The key factors in this move will be social, and they are working both within the US, where the will to support a superpower role may well be waning, and outside it, where the US is likely to find ever fewer followers, whether it wants to lead or not. It is interesting to note how many commentators on US politics make the point that the US is more likely to be driven out of its superpower status by the unwillingness of its citizens to support the role than by the rise of any external challenger.⁷ And externally, Waltz was right in his prediction that 'countries that wield overwhelming power will be tempted to misuse it. And even when their use of power is not an abuse, other states will see it as being so'.⁸ Several other American realists echo this worry, observing that there is already a disjuncture between a US self-perception of benign leadership, and a widespread image of it elsewhere as a threat whose foreign policy, particularly on trade and the Middle East, is driven overwhelmingly by domestic politics.⁹ The superpower status of the US rests as much, or possibly more, on its social status as on its material capability. The fact that Japan and Europe broadly accept American leadership gives the US legitimacy, and insulates it from the formation of a counter-pole coalition. Changes in social support on either the domestic or international level could thus quite quickly shift the US from superpower to great power status.

Given the hyperactivity of US global political and military engagement since 1947, it is easy to forget that isolationism was the country's founding creed. And as Darwin notes: 'The American political system seemed poorly equipped for the formulation and conduct of foreign policy, the continuity of which was easily wrecked on the shoals of domestic controversy'.¹⁰ The division of powers plus a widespread disinterest and ignorance among the citizenry about the rest of the world explain why Washington has needed to use crusading, securitizing rhetoric to sustain support for an activist global foreign policy. The peripheral geographical positioning that once underpinned isolationism still gives the US the option of detached offshore balancing.¹¹ This policy requires only that the US prevent any one power from becoming dominant in Eurasia, as Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union aspired to do, and thus able to threaten the US. Otherwise it can leave the rest of the world to look after itself. It is not impossible to imagine the US being tempted to abandon its experiment in crusading liberalism and reverting to the more detached revolutionary purism of being the 'city on the hill'.

Since the end of the Cold War, America's military-political global engagement has been costly, unpopular and often unsuccessful. It has won the US more enemies than friends, and increasingly lacks the ideological drivers that made its engagements in two world wars and the Cold War so successful. Domestically, the liberal internationalist coalition that underpinned America's outward turn after the Second World War has irretrievably dissolved into bitter party polarization.¹² The misguided occupation of Iraq has left the US worse off in both security and economic terms, and is an exemplar of extremely expensive policy failure. The 'global war on terror' (GWoT) has failed to provide the basis for a new crusade, degraded the freedoms and civil liberties that the US stands for, and eviscerated its liberal reputation by exposing the willingness of the US to resort to torture.

If the internal factor is about the willingness of the US to play the leadership role necessary for it to be a superpower, the external one is about whether, even if it continues to want to lead, its legitimacy to do so will be accepted by others. Material weakening and erosion of the will to lead can of course both affect the willingness of others to follow, but perhaps more important than either of these, and considerably independent of them, is the declining attractiveness and legitimacy of the US as the sole superpower and leader of international society. On one level, the US has been impressively successful in fulfilling Nye's injunction that it needs 'other countries to want what it wants'.¹³ It seems unlikely that the US, the EU and Japan will drift away from their strong commitment to democracy and market economies, or that China and India will reverse the economic reform and opening up on which their increasing wealth and power now depend. But, as many have observed, the US position is increasingly contradictory.¹⁴ Washington wants to lead and be supported by international society, while at the same time using both its own sense of exceptionalism and its role as leader to exempt itself from many of the rules that it wants others to observe: what John Ruggie has tellingly labeled 'American exemptionalism'.¹⁵ It, thus, both violates the rules it claims to be defending, and claims strong sovereignty for itself against intervention by others, while preserving its own right to violate the sovereignty of others in pursuit of its own objectives. Here lies the basis of the seemingly oxymoronic charge of 'liberal imperialism'. Because of this contradiction, the standing of the US is in notable decline on three levels: the acceptability of its policies, its attractiveness as a model of the future and the illegitimacy in international society of hegemony in any form.

Acceptability of US policies. The US, of course, has never been short of unpopular foreign policies. From Cuba, Vietnam and Chile, and limited nuclear war, through its unquestioning support for Israel and its occupation of Iraq, to obstructionism on controlling climate change and the use of torture, US policy has often been controversial among its friends. There has never been a golden age when the US was universally admired by the rest of the world. But during the Cold War, and to an extent in the 1990s, the impact of particular disaffections was offset by the widespread general sense that the West and its hangers-on were a lot better off with US leadership than without it. Over the last decade that general sense has weakened rapidly, partly because there is no longer any great ideological struggle to sustain it, and partly because of the conspicuous turn to self-interested unilateralism that marked the eight years of the Bush administration. A striking symbol of this was the replacement of talk about 'friends and allies' or 'the free world' with a harsher instrumental line about 'coalitions of the willing'. This rhetorical shift seemed to abandon any US interest or belief in long-term friendships and alliances, and replace it with a rational choice logic of immediate and specific shared interest. The US had rather limited success in selling the GWOt as a global macro-securitization to replace the Cold War,¹⁶ and, as a consequence, the particular policies of the US now stand largely on their own terms, unshielded by the mediating effects of any overarching common cause or closely shared identity. A brief look at three key policy areas – the Middle East/GWOt, China and climate change – shows how the US stands ever more alone.

Disagreements over policy in the Middle East already rank as one of the conspicuous areas of disaffection between the US and Europe, and this seems set to continue.¹⁷ The Middle East is a profound mess and is likely to remain so. The main point for the

question of US superpower legitimacy is that many of the US interventions in the Middle East, both those of the Bush administration and those more long-standing, are widely perceived to have been counterproductive, not only feeding the terrorist problem,¹⁸ but also deepening the many tragedies in the region. The occupation of Iraq in 2003 looks set to generate far more and bigger problems than it has solved. More or less unconditional US support for Israel is a perennial Washington idiosyncrasy that inspires little enthusiasm elsewhere, and has so far hamstrung the US from pushing decisively towards a two-state solution to the Israel–Palestine problem. The Obama administration's more robust line on the necessity of a two-state solution faces such daunting domestic and regional obstacles that its chances do not look promising. This festering sore has grown steadily worse, with Israel creating ever more difficult facts on the ground, and assisting in the self-destruction of its Palestinian negotiating partner. US support for the Saudi regime helps keep in power a government whose domestic deals with Wahabi Islamists recycles large sums of oil money into the support of Islamic fundamentalism, though here it has to be said that Europeans are just as culpable. Perhaps only on the question of preventing the proliferation of nuclear weapons does US policy in the Middle East enjoy much support, but even that is undermined by the hypocrisy of the US turning a blind eye to Israel's substantial nuclear arsenal while seeking to forbid Arab states and Iran from acquiring their own deterrents.

During the Cold War the unattractive elements of US policy in the Middle East were masked by the general agreement on the need to contain the Soviet Union. The GWoT not only failed to extend this cover, but also amplified differences between the US and its allies. After the Iraq fiasco and the Afghan quagmire, even ever-faithful Britain would have trouble joining in any new US intervention in this region. Russia, China, Japan and increasingly India have their own interests there, which are often in competition with those of the US. Given both the deep divisions and antagonisms in the Middle East, and its effective fragmentation by the West,¹⁹ the possibility of regional stability looks remote. The US tie to Israel looks unlikely to change and will continue to poison Washington's position in the region and much of the rest of the world. Unpopular US policies and competing interests in the region from other powers provide no foundations for legitimising US leadership.

US policy on China, though less controversial than that on the Middle East, also benefited from the masking effects of shared interests. During the Cold War, containment of China was part of the East–West struggle, and US cultivation of China after 1971 helped to weaken the Soviet Union. The US role in facilitating China's 'reform and opening up' since 1978 has also been broadly popular. What is now in prospect, however, is that the long-standing drumbeat of concern in Washington about rising China as a peer competitor will get louder as China does indeed grow in power.²⁰ To the extent that realist thinking dominates in Washington, and the US retains its commitment to not tolerating any peer competitors, then a rising China, whether peaceful or not, *must* appear threatening to the US. The nature of the China that rises, however, will be crucial to whether others share US perceptions of China as a threat. In the absence of any common cause, it is far from clear that other powers will feel threatened by China's challenge to US hegemony.

If a rising China becomes ultra-nationalist, aggressive and militarist, then it could well be that others would share US perceptions. But the Chinese leadership is determined

to avoid the mistakes made by Germany, Japan and the Soviet Union in their rising period.²¹ If they can carry off their design for a 'peaceful rise', then it becomes possible that US perceptions of China as threatening will not be shared widely, if at all. Those many voices currently in opposition to US hegemony, and speaking of the need for a more multipolar world order, might welcome China's rise. If China is relatively benign in the sense of not using violence against its neighbours, and staying broadly within the rules of the global economic order, Europe will not care much about its rise, and will not feel threatened by it. Russia has worries about Chinese designs on the sparsely populated territories of the Russian Far East. Yet the two countries have developed a quite stable strategic partnership,²² have many useful economic complementarities, and share an interest in non-intervention and regime security. Russia may well want to continue to bandwagon with China against the US. India has to balance a growing economic relationship with China against some still sensitive territorial disputes and a desire not to be overshadowed in status terms by China. Unless China turns nasty and threatening, India will probably try to continue to play the US and China against each other as it does now, leaving the main economic and political costs of balancing China to the US.²³

The big question mark is Japan, which since the end of the Cold War has not only maintained, but somewhat strengthened, its alliance with the US, and whose relationship with China remains deeply clouded by unsettled historical issues. A considerable weight of expert opinion thinks that Sino-Japanese relations are, underneath their formal political correctness, bad and, on the level of society and public opinion, getting worse, with both governments in different ways to blame.²⁴ If China's rise is benign, but the US securitizes it anyway, Japan will face very difficult choices. If it stays with the US, it would find itself being the front line in a new Cold War between Washington and Beijing. That might not look attractive compared with the options of either resolving the history problems and bandwagoning with China or following India into a more independent, middle-ground position between Washington and Beijing. Japan is the toughest problem facing China's 'peaceful rise' strategy. But if China conducts its peaceful rise successfully, this US concern will be a parochial one, shared by few, possibly none, of the other great powers. If China plays its hand cleverly, it could put the US more on its own in relation to great power politics than it has been since before the First World War.

Climate change is a relatively new issue with only slight links back to the Cold War. It poses questions of common fate for all of humankind and, if rising temperatures and sea levels are to be controlled, requires collective action of a kind with serious economic consequences. This could easily become the dominant issue for world politics, though the scientific uncertainties are still sufficient that the exact timing and unfolding of it are difficult to predict. Yet the US is already unpopular on climate change. The commitment of Americans to a high consumption lifestyle, and the Bush administration's resistance to serious pollution and emission controls, whether domestic or international, and even denial that there was a problem, has in the eyes of many made the US more a part of the problem than of the solution. Obama's enthusiasm for green energy as a fix for both the environment and the economy has already been checked by the polarization in US politics, though developments in the private sector and at the level of state and city governments might well restore some US credibility in this area. However, it is less clear that there is any fix for the problem of the unsustainable American lifestyle, and the

polarization of US politics will make it difficult, if not impossible, for the US to avoid remaining a big part of the problem.

The US as a model and its claim to own the future. In addition to standing increasingly on its own in the main areas of international policy, the US is losing its claim to be a model and to own the future. That claim has long been based on the US championing of political liberal values in the form of democracy and human rights, and economic liberal values in the form of free(r) trade and financial liberalization. There was a very substantial element of hypocrisy in this position during the Cold War, yet, even so, much was done. At this point, however, there is little scope left for the US to legitimize its leadership by appealing to liberal values either political or economic. On the political side, the GWoT means that Washington is still under pressure to prefer anti-terrorist governments to democratic ones. US abuses of human rights at Abu Ghraib and Guantanamo, its policy of 'extraordinary renditions' and acceptance of de facto torture, as well as its fierce resistance to the International Criminal Court, have gutted Washington's credibility to say much about human rights. In some ways the 'civilian power' EU is now a better representative of political liberal values. The Obama administration has a huge amount of damage to repair before it can present the US as a beacon of political liberalism, and its weakening position in Congress does not augur well.

In terms of economic liberalism, the Obama inheritance is even worse. Under Clinton and Bush, the financial world took on a globalised life of its own. Even before the current economic crisis, competitors to the dollar as reserve currency were on the rise, and US indebtedness was weakening its position. On trade, the US had largely ceased to lead anyway, its weakening economic position making it more protectionist. Obama's options are massively constrained by the magnitude of the economic crisis. It is not clear that he is an economic liberal, and, even if he is, many Democrats in Congress look likely to be even less enthusiastic about further trade liberalisation than the Bush Republicans were. The US led the world into this recession, and, badly damaged itself, cannot lead the world out of it. It has neither the economic resources, nor, with the collapse of the Washington consensus, the ideological authority to do so. If the world economy can be managed globally at all, it will have to be done collectively (e.g. via the G20 and other suchlike groups of leading powers), giving bigger voices to other players. With the Washington consensus discredited, other ideas about how to run the global political economy are in play, both European social markets, and the Beijing consensus.²⁵ The truth of Bromley's observation has been amplified by recent events: 'US economic leadership power exists but it is a wasting asset ... governance of the world economy is something that would have to be accomplished collectively if it is to be accomplished at all.'²⁶ If attempts to get the global economy going again fail, or are too protracted and costly, then the emergence of a more regionalized world political economy becomes more likely (more on this later).

So America's claim to represent the (liberal) future is now blighted both by its own failures and by the shortcomings of the liberal model itself. Whether an unsustainable 'American way of life' is an appropriate model for the rest of the world, and whether the US economic model is either sustainable or desirable, are now both more open to serious question. When the world looks at American health and welfare policies; at the financial

mess; at a seeming US inclination to use force as the first-choice policy instrument; at the influence of religion and special interest lobbies in US domestic politics; at a US government that under Bush was openly comfortable with the use of torture and was re-elected; and at a federal environmental policy until recently in denial about global warming, it now more easily asks not just whether the US is a questionable model, but whether it has become a serious part of the problem. The EU model looks more attractive to some, and the emergent Chinese model to others. While some of this negative image was specific to the Bush administration, and is being turned around by Obama, many of the deeper issues are structural. The US is much more culturally conservative, religious, individualistic and anti-state than most other parts of the West. Its religiosity, cultural conservatism and anti-statism set it apart from most of Europe, while its individualism and anti-statism set it apart from Asia. The US is no longer the only model of the future in play, and it is far from clear that it will ever be able to recover the leading position that it once possessed.

The illegitimacy of hegemony in international society. The third factor weakening the position of the US is not so much to do with the US itself as with the rising unacceptability of any state being hegemonic in international society. The problem is the very fact of unipolarity itself. Several English School writers take a social view of the hegemony problem. They argue that although the legitimacy of contemporary international society is based on the principle of sovereign equality, and up to a point the equality of people and nations, it is still riddled with the hegemonic/hierarchical practices and inequalities of status left over from the period of Western world domination and empire.²⁷ With the shift to unipolarity, the US became the principal representative and exponent of the hegemonic practice by which the West continues to dominate international society. There is no 'satisfactory principle of hegemony – rooted in a plausibly wide consensus'²⁸ with which international society might bridge this gap between its principles and its practices. A concentration of power in one actor, as Clark, echoing Waltz, observes, disrupts the ideas of balance and equilibrium that are the traditional sources and conditions for legitimacy in international society.²⁹ This problem would arise for any unipolar power, but it also connects back to the specific US legitimacy deficit in which, under the Bush administration, the US lost sight of what Watson calls *raison de système* ('the belief that it pays to make the system work'), and this exacerbated what is anyway the illegitimacy of hegemony in itself.³⁰ This way of thinking lines up with Lake's arguments about the importance of authority in legitimizing hierarchy. His arguments about the 'conferral of rights by the ruled' link to much older arguments that 'the viability of colonial governments ultimately rested on goodwill and cooperation rather than on enforced obedience'.³¹

This problem is not going to go away. Regarding the US, Calleo argues that, Obama notwithstanding, 'hegemony is likely to remain the recurring obsession of its official imagination, the *idée fixe* of its foreign policy'.³² More generally, anti-hegemonism is an emergent property of post-colonial international society. As the two-century old power gap closes, the rise of non-Western powers such as India and China will increase resistance to the residuals of American/Western hegemony. Even where there is no new rising great power, as in the Middle East, the force of anti-hegemonic opinion is already clear. The general background of anti-hegemonism goes a long way towards explaining the specific policy problems for the US in relation to the Middle East and China.

Taking all this into account, there is a good case for thinking that the standing of the US as the sole superpower is fragile. This fragility is more based on social factors within and outside the US than it is on material ones, and on all three social aspects – the acceptability of its policies, its attractiveness as a model of the future, and the (il)legitimacy in international society of hegemony – the position of the US is weak. The dependence of US superpower status on both the willingness of others to follow it and the willingness of US citizens to support it has been masked by realist ways of thinking that put too much emphasis on material capability alone. The 2008 economic crisis, however, has caused even that mask to slip, and a leader without followers will soon become just an ordinary great power, even if still the first among equals.

(ii) *China*

If the US is not likely to last long as the sole superpower, what is to stop a rising China from stepping into its shoes, perhaps generating a dangerous power transition crisis along the way? The same framework of material–social and domestic–international can be used to interrogate China's case, as can the questions of policy, model and hegemony.

China certainly presents the most promising all-round profile as a potential new superpower. In material terms it has a fast-growing and rapidly modernizing economy. Although still technologically and organizationally behind in some respects, China is successfully mastering many key technologies, and is making sustained progress across the board in economic development. On the back of this expanding economy it is modernizing its conventional forces and upgrading a modest nuclear deterrent. Even though China does not yet have the material capability for superpower status, its growth might eventually deliver them. That delivery depends on a number of inherently unpredictable variables, not least of which is how China handles the inevitable social strains and booms and busts that accompany all forms of capitalist development. China is not rising by itself however. While its material capabilities may well become formidable in an absolute sense, China is, like the US, locked into the much talked about 'rise of the rest'. In relative terms, the rise of the rest makes it increasingly difficult for any state to achieve the material capacity for global dominance. Regardless of this, and again as with the US, the main issues confronting China as a possible superpower are social rather than material. While the US is losing the social attributes that supported its superpower standing, China has yet to acquire them, and it is far from clear that it is well placed to do so.

In domestic terms China seems to be divided about whether or not it is ready to take on a superpower role. On the nationalist wing there is justified pride in China's accomplishments, and an eagerness to regain top international status as a way of leaving behind the bitter memory of the 'century of humiliation'. If the more strident nationalist tendency comes to dominate in China, and the country begins to throw its weight around, it would destroy the peaceful rise strategy, make China seem threatening to both its neighbours and the US, and undermine its position in international society.

Yet so far China's current behaviour remains more in thrall to Deng's famous advice that China should keep a low profile during its rise, bide its time, conceal its capabilities and avoid leadership.³³ Above all it wants to avoid falling into open rivalry with the US. Speeches given by President Hu put strong emphasis on a strict interpretation of sovereign

equality and non-intervention, and the desirability of preserving the distinctiveness of cultures, social systems and paths of development.³⁴ China stands against hegemony and for a more equal role for developing countries in world politics, and it appears to be silent on whether or not great powers should have a privileged management role in a multipolar system. The leadership has no coherent grand strategy, its outlook is defensive and it is primarily concerned about maintaining internal stability and development.³⁵ Indeed, it sees China's development as its principal contribution to the world, helping to build common prosperity and increasing the sum of human knowledge and technology.³⁶ In effect, China is saying that its own problems of development are sufficiently huge that they absorb all of its capacity to manage, and that because China is so large a part of humankind, successful management of its own development will benefit everyone. If this tendency dominates, then China seems unready in itself to take up the burdens of a superpower role. Although it has come a long way in its diplomatic engagement, China is in some ways still playing the 'diplomatic apprentice' in international society.³⁷

On the external side, the most striking fact about China is that it has no major power friends. Its 'strategic partnership' with Russia is more one of convenience between mutually suspicious authoritarian regimes. Both are more opposed to the US/West than they are fearful of each other and, because they are geographical neighbours, both need to manage their borders and spheres of influence.³⁸ This lack of powerful friends means that China has little of the political capital necessary to build a superpower position.

Acceptability of China's policies. In terms of the acceptability of its policies, China has far less baggage than the US. Much of its policy is regionally focused. Its wider-ranging policies towards the US, Iran and Africa may be controversial in the West, but they are broadly acceptable in many other quarters. On the specific issue of climate change, China's recent performance at the Copenhagen summit suggests that it, like the US, is a prisoner of its domestic concerns and in danger, therefore, of being seen as part of the problem.

More important in China's case than specific policies is the question of its overall lack of legitimacy as a leader in international society. As noted earlier, and as I have argued in detail elsewhere,³⁹ China does not yet seem to have a coherent view of either what kind of state it wants to be, or what kind of international society it would like to be part of. To the extent that its vision can be inferred, it seems to offer a mix of economic liberalism and political and social conservatism that would be either unacceptable to most Western countries (because it fails to link together the economic and political sides of the liberal agenda in a positive view of cultural and political convergence), or impossible (because the operation of the global market is too powerful to coexist with big cultural and political differences and one or the other has to give). It is easy to see the political attraction of this combination to China's leaders, because it allows China to remain both non-Western and non-democratic, while at the same time allowing it to rise peacefully on the back of the global market and interdependence. The contradictions in the Chinese view play to those non-Chinese of a realist disposition who fear that a risen China will play ruthless power politics once it has the capability. In other words, for realist-minded outsiders it is easy to read China's vision as simply wanting to take the advantages of participating in the global economy in order to increase its power and wealth, without paying the cost of social and political convergence. In the liberal perspective, it is only the social

and political convergence (liberal democratic peace) that makes the interdependence of the global market acceptable in political and security terms. A rising non-democratic power thus threatens the stability of the international society on which its rise depends. As Ramo argues, echoing Nye's injunction to the US cited earlier: 'If China wants to ... achieve Peaceful Rise, it is crucially important that it get other nations to buy into the world view it proposes'.⁴⁰ As long as China has a communist government, even one advocating market communism, it is unclear how it can escape from this dilemma. Being an ideological outlier in international society poses huge difficulties for China's acceptability as a superpower.

China as a model. Part of America's strength as a superpower was its standing as a model for others. Its conspicuous economic and cultural success, and the claimed foundation for this success in a universally applicable liberal ideology, underpinned the claim of the US to own the future of humankind. China's current model of authoritarian development might well be superficially attractive to leaderships in many developing countries, but there are big questions about how sustainable it is, and how applicable it is to other countries. China no longer represents a coherent ideology, and its self-centred view of its own development is symbolised for outsiders by the often-heard phrase 'Chinese characteristics', with its suggestion of an inward-looking type of national exceptionalism. Unlike the universalist pretensions of American liberalism, 'Chinese characteristics' points to a culturally unique way of doing things that is not necessarily relevant to those outside Chinese culture. China, therefore, does not have the kind of soft power given by representing either a universalist ideology or a free civil society, and is much less well placed than the US to get its benign self-view accepted abroad. In addition, its unique size and history do not make it an easy model for others to emulate.

The illegitimacy of hegemony in international society. At the global level, a rising China faces the same general opposition to hegemony as the US; although the US has the benefit both of a reputational carry-over from its successful leadership during the Cold War, and the still significant residual appeal of its universal ideology. China, however, has neither, and its outlier status in ideological terms means that it faces an uphill struggle to avoid triggering anti-hegemonic responses, both regionally and globally, as its power grows.

One can conclude both that China is not really ready to take up a superpower role and that it is not well positioned globally to do so. Its material progress is promising, but is the relatively easy part. On the social side, the problems are much more formidable. Unlike the US, China does not yet have much to offer by way of establishing its legitimacy as a global leader. It represents no universal ideology and has no clear vision of how international society should be organized. Neither its communism nor its nationalism has much appeal outside its borders, and, given the country's many unique characteristics, it is far from clear how applicable its development model is to others. China has in some ways moved beyond its 'apprentice' phase in its international relations, but it has few of the social resources, either internal or external, necessary for claiming legitimacy as a global superpower.

(iii) The EU

The EU is still surprisingly widely talked about as a potential superpower,⁴¹ but despite its promise in some factors it has one fatal flaw. In material terms, the EU is second only to the US in overall size and capability of its economy, command of technology, finance and suchlike. Its military capability is far behind that of the US and more comparable with that of China, but that is not the EU's main problem in the superpower stakes.

In social terms, at the international level the EU looks in many ways to be better placed than either the US or China. It has high overall legitimacy as representative of a middle-ground social democracy that avoids the extremes of both Washington's neoliberalism and Beijing's authoritarian capitalism. Its foreign policy record is pretty good. Many like what the EU does in the Middle East and on the environment, and wish it would do more and develop a stronger presence. The EU has no politico-military or status rivalries with other rising powers such as China, India or Brazil, and does not seem even to feature much in the US's concerns about rising peer competitors. Perhaps its only troubled relationship is with Russia, but then Russia has many troubled relationships. The EU also has considerable standing as a model and comparator for other regional integration projects. Although not everyone else wants to go down the institutionalized regional integration model pioneered by the EU, it is unquestionably the most successful in creating a post-Westphalian form of international political economy based on inter-governmental organizations. It is admired as a security community in which some very deep historical enmities have been put firmly in the past. The EU even has less trouble with anti-hegemony than either the US or China. Given its intrinsically regional basis, it is well placed to avoid the suspicions by outsiders of hegemonic intent that attach to both American and Chinese power. Many of its neighbours from Eastern Europe through Turkey and Georgia to Morocco want to join.

Despite all of these promising qualities, the fatal flaw lies in the EU's domestic society and politics. There is little support at the level of the citizenry for the EU to have a larger and wider international engagement, and the EU's political elites are divided on the question. Their recent failure to use the new roles of the President of the European Council and the High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy to upgrade the EU's actor capacity internationally is but the latest symptom of the EU's deep unwillingness to become a coherent actor on the global stage. Minor political figures have been appointed to the new jobs, and there is no significant concentration of authority or increase in decision-making capacity. In socio-political terms, the EU is in a state of domestic unreadiness for a superpower role that makes China look like a model of political coherence, and even makes chronically reticent Japan look robust. Realists will of course attribute this weakness to the fact that the EU is not a state, and therefore lacks the political coherence to be a superpower. There is something in that argument, but it does not cover the whole case. It is entirely possible to envisage a *sui generis* post-modern entity like the EU acting as a new kind of superpower in a globalizing world. Talk of 'normative' and 'civilian' power Europe hints at this,⁴² and suggests that China and the US might be a bit old-fashioned in their materialist, *machtropolitik* approach to superpowerdom. If this option to be a postmodern superpower does exist, the EU has not taken it and does not look to be capable of doing so for the foreseeable future.

I conclude that there is a good chance that the US will fail to sustain its current position as the sole superpower, and that no other state will rise to that rank. If this prognostication is correct, then the emergent post-colonial world order will have no superpowers, but several great powers. The natural dynamic of such a world will be towards a more regionalized international order.⁴³

Why a More Regionalized International Order?

Why should the natural dynamic of a post-colonial world with no superpowers and several great powers be towards a regionalized international order and what would this look like in practice? Any argument in favour of a regionalizing scenario has to establish the material and social foundations for regions along the same lines as used to discuss superpowers in the previous section. It has to show how a territorializing practice such as regionalization can prevail in a world in which globalization has been having strong deterritorializing effects.

The material foundations for a regionalized order are quite easy to see, and follow on directly from the discussion about the US, China and the EU in the previous section. There is not much dispute that the international system is moving towards a less uneven distribution of power. In the shorter term, the unnatural dominance of the US in the years following the Second World War has been steadily eroded, first by the recovery of Europe and Japan and later by the rise of new economic powers. In the longer term, the huge predominance that enabled the West and Japan to overwhelm the rest of the world during the 19th century is steadily giving way as modernization spreads more widely through the international system. Japan was the first non-Western state to achieve modern great power standing over a century ago. China has now joined the ranks, and India seems not far behind. In addition there are a number of substantial industrializing regional powers such as Brazil, South Africa and Turkey. The steady spread of industrialization and modernization to more and more countries is partly a matter of national policy and partly a result of the natural systemic mechanisms of capitalism. Diffusing the foundations of power ever more widely not only generates new great and regional powers, but also makes it increasingly difficult for any state to achieve the relative capability necessary for superpower status. A corollary of diffusion is that it is not only relative capability that is affected, but also absolute capability. As illustrated in Vietnam, Somalia, Afghanistan and Iraq, it is no longer possible even for superpowers easily to occupy countries where there is firm local resistance. Furthermore, as shown by Israel, South Africa, North Korea, Pakistan and probably soon Iran, even quite modest powers can acquire minimum nuclear deterrents. The world is returning to something like the more natural, even distribution of power that existed before power became extremely concentrated in the West.

The social foundations for a regionalized order start from the strong anti-hegemonism discussed in the previous section. This is expressed in widespread calls for a more multipolar international system. Only in some parts of the EU (most obviously Britain and Eastern Europe) and Japan is there real enthusiasm for the maintenance of US hegemony. Added to this is the significant likelihood of a partial retreat from globalization, particularly financial liberalization, following the economic crisis starting in 2008. The Washington consensus is as dead as communism, and what has been demonstrated

is the political inability to manage a financially liberalized global economy. It is not so much an overstretch of US power (though that too) as an overstretch of global management capacity. Hegemonic stability has proved flawed, and there is insufficient consensus on which to build the necessary collective global management. The economic crisis has made clearer what was already becoming obvious in the 1990s and 2000s, namely that the Western victory over the Soviet project was not going to usher in a world homogenized along Western lines. Although nearly all accepted that some form of capitalism was the only way forward, there were many variations on this theme. There is also no consensus about either democracy or Western versions of human rights, and while there is a strong consensus about the equality of peoples, there is none about individualism versus collectivism or about the role of religion in political life (never mind the additional difference about which religion). The system level is thus in many ways ripe for regionalization along lines defined by political, economic and cultural comfort zones.

Speculations about the nature of a benign regionalized international order have been around for a long time in the IR literature, and generally rest on the assumption of a world organized around three cores: the US, the EU and East Asia.⁴⁴ The practice of regionalization is already well established. Its emergence can be explained as a response to globalization both as a fallback against the possible failure of globalization, and as a strategy to acquire more weight to operate in a globalized world. The EU and NAFTA are only the most obvious examples of this development. To them can be added Mercosur, ASEAN, the CIS, SARC, SADC, SCO, ECOWAS and other regional groupings built around economic and political cooperation. Of course, not all of these are equally successful or influential, but they do show how widespread the regionalizing impulse is, and in the backwash of the current economic crisis and decline of US leadership this impulse has every opportunity to grow stronger.

That said, existing practice does not provide a clear template for what a regionalized world order would look like. It could, as the list of regional organizations just given suggests, be quite fragmented, with anything up to a dozen regions. Or it could, as the scenarios of Kupchan and Helleiner suggest, be concentrated into three big groupings. Would South America go with the US along NAFTA lines, or could Brazil be the core of its own regional grouping? Will the West dissolve into American- and EU-centred groupings or will Atlanticism define a larger core? What happens to sub-Saharan Africa and the Middle East where there are neither core powers, nor shared institutions strong enough to sustain a coherent region? These are interesting and important questions, but the uncertainties they raise do not stand in the way of concluding that in a world without superpowers, the general move towards a more regionalized international order is both plausible and quite likely. Sub-Saharan Africa and the Middle East are going to be troublesome zones under any scenario. Which great powers end up associated with which region, or decide to form their own, is less important than the dynamics pushing towards some form of regionalized international order.

Why Not Worry?

There are many reasons to think that a regionalized international order would work quite well. The generic worry about such an order stems from the experience of most of the

20th century, when imperial powers competed with each other either over their spheres of influence or over whether one of them could dominate the whole world, and the 1930s' experience is often cited as a warning against going down this route.⁴⁵ For several reasons the danger of a struggle for global hegemony seems no longer very salient. First, the West is in relative decline, and other regions are mainly defensive in outlook, trying to maintain their political and cultural characteristics, and find their own route to modernization, against Western pressure. Nobody else obviously wants the job of global leader. Second any potential global hegemon will be constrained both by the breadth and depth of anti-hegemonism, and by the difficulty of acquiring the necessary material preponderance and social standing. Third, there are no deep ideological or racist differences to fuel conflict like those that dominated the 20th century. Fourth, all the great powers fear both war and economic breakdown, and have a commitment to maintaining world trade. Nobody wants to go back to the autarchic, empire-building days of the 1930s.

In addition, a good case can be made that sufficient shared values exist to underpin a reasonable degree of global-level coexistence and cooperation even in a more regionalized international order. Logics additional to Waltz's unit veto ideas about the proliferation of nuclear weapons⁴⁶ are in play: cultural, political and economic factors can also work to produce a stable international order. The world will certainly divide on whether the move towards such an order is a good thing or not. Liberals, both in the West and elsewhere, will lament the weakening of their universalist project, and fear the rise of various parochialisms, some possibly quite nasty. Whatever its merits, a more regionalized world order would mark a retreat from universalist liberal agendas of both a political and an economic sort. The loss of hegemonic leadership would probably mean a reduction in the overall management capacity of the system, though even that is not a given. One should not underestimate the possibilities for innovation on this front once the now in-built habit of dependence on US leadership is broken. On the economic side, regions would still provide a halfway house for economies of scale, and there would still be a lot of global trade and cooperation on many functional matters from big science to environmental management. It is not without significance that even during the depths of the Cold War, the Americans and the Soviets were able to negotiate on common survival issues such as nuclear testing, non-proliferation and arms control. However, there would no longer be an attempt to run a financially integrated global economy.

Some in the West would be relieved to end an increasingly outdated, unsuccessful, unpopular and costly hegemony, and many in other parts of the world would be equally glad to get the West off their backs. For those who think that the tensions among a rampant global economy, a thin interstate society and a humankind still deeply divided by identities laid down centuries or millennia ago are becoming too great to handle, some retreat from the overambitions of global governance might be welcome. Perhaps the premature attempt at global governance has created more management problems than current human social and political capacities are able to solve. A less ambitious world order, with regions looking after themselves more, might well remain peaceful and involve fewer frictions and failures. A consensus might emerge that a period of regional-scale experiments in organizing a capitalist political economy is desirable before any return to global governance is attempted.

The big question would be whether a world regionalized in this way could still come up with the level of global management necessary to deal with collective problems such as climate change, crime, terrorism, trade, migration and arms control. Grounds for confidence here can be found in the degree to which a number of key institutions have been naturalized across nearly all of international society. Some of the more liberal institutions (democracy, human rights) are of course contested even at the elite level. Yet quite a few other institutions have become substantially naturalized across many populations. At the level of state elites, sovereignty, territoriality, non-intervention, diplomacy, international law, great power management, nationalism, self-determination (not all versions), popular sovereignty, progress, equality of people(s) and, up to a point, the market (more for trade and production than finance) are all pretty deeply internalized and not contested as principles. Particular instances or applications may excite controversy, but the basic institutions of a pluralist, coexistence, interstate society have wide support among states, and pretty wide support amongst peoples and transnational actors. Most liberation movements seek sovereignty. Most peoples are comfortable with nationalism, territoriality, sovereignty and the idea of progress. Most transnational actors want and need a stable legal framework. Even as Western power declines, it does not seem unreasonable to think that most of these pluralist institutions will remain in place, as too might the modest, and hopefully increasing, level of commitment to environmental stewardship.

These shared institutions provide an important foundation for the maintenance of international order among regional international societies. The reduced management capacity caused by weaker leadership and the removal of hegemony at the global level would to some extent be balanced by a reduced agenda of things to be managed. A world without a central hegemony would have much less Western interference in other parts of the world, and therefore might well have fewer of the type of global problems that arise from such interference, such as al Qaeda. Tensions over hegemonic interventions would decline if regions were, for better or worse, left more to handle their own affairs. There might also be a considerably more modest view of how much economic integration was desirable at the global level. A regionalized world under contemporary conditions would not look like the 1930s. Its interaction culture⁴⁷ would be one of friends and rivals, not one of rivals and enemies.

Downsides?

The main danger in a no-superpower system is that one or more great powers will seek to reoccupy a superpower role, but that seems unlikely under contemporary conditions. The other danger is of more local great power rivalries about boundaries and spheres of influence. The geographical separation of a globally distributed set of great powers makes Asia the most likely area for this problem because of its concentration of substantial and rising powers. But even in Asia, the diffusion of power and aversion to being seen as imperialist makes major conflicts unlikely. Unlike before 1945, empire-building is deeply unfashionable, and there are few signs that Russia, China, Japan and/or India want to become major rivals over territory or spheres of influence.

Perhaps the key downside risk of a more regionalized international order is that smaller states and peoples *within* regions would be at risk of becoming the vassals of their local suzerain power(s), and having little or no recourse to outside help or support

other than disaster relief. Signs of this problem are visible in the long-standing concerns of India's South Asian neighbours about New Delhi's dominance in the region, and in the worries of Vietnam, Malaysia, Indonesia and the Philippines about China's extensive claims in the South China Sea. Thus, the most obvious logical flaw in the argument for a broadly benign view of a more regionalized international order is that the widespread anti-hegemonism that works against superpowers globally will also work against the dominant power(s) in a region. Some might well fear that the hegemonic dynamics of their local region will be nastier than Western hegemony. Russia does not hesitate to use force and coercion against its weaker neighbours. India's smaller neighbours, especially Pakistan, vigorously resist its hegemony. Historical memories weigh heavily against both Japan and China as leaders in East Asia. The US has long been less than loved by its neighbours in Latin America. South Africa's dominance in its sphere is resented by some of its neighbours. In the Middle East, any moves towards leadership by Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Iran or Iraq are immediately contested by the others.

There is no doubt that a regionalized world would present a rather varied picture in this respect. Some regions, most obviously the EU and North America, already possess robust intergovernmental organizations and habits that can mediate concerns about hegemony. Others, such as South America and increasingly East Asia, possess quite good institutions that may well be able to play this role. Yet others, such as West and Southern Africa, South Asia, and the Middle East, have institutions that may be too feeble to mediate local concerns about hegemony. There might well also be zones of conflict in parts of Africa and the Middle East where no local powers are strong enough to provide regional order, disputes are many, and local groups are armed and ready to fight. This sounds bad, but in practice might not be worse than what already exists in those regions. The arguments about zones of peace and zones of chaos⁴⁸ will hold regardless of the scenarios about great powers and superpowers discussed in this article. If outsiders were less involved, there would be less political spillover and blowback. Where institutions are weak, a lot will depend on the distribution of power and the attitude of the powerful. Where the distribution of power is diffuse, as in the Middle East, perhaps the best that can be hoped for is a managed balance of power. Where power is concentrated, as in the former Soviet Union and South and East Asia, much will depend on the policy of the leading power(s).

In this respect, China's policy of peaceful rise may be a pointer. The Chinese government is aware of the problem of anti-hegemonic reactions to its rise and, with the exception of its bitter relationship with Japan, mostly seeks to behave as a good neighbour. Since China, India and Brazil have such strong anti-hegemonic traditions themselves, there is ground for hope that, as a more regional based world order emerges, they will be able to manage both the anti-hegemonic concerns of the smaller states within their region, and their relations with other great powers and their regions.

Conclusions

I have argued here for a 'third way' between those who believe in ongoing US hegemony and those who believe in the necessity for the US to take a more accommodative leadership role in a multi-power world order. This 'third way' departs from the essentially Western status quo motivation of the mainstream debates and both expects and welcomes

a more radical transformation in the world order. In this 'third way', there are no superpowers only great powers and regional powers, capitalism in various versions is the accepted form of political economy, regional orders are stronger than the global one, and at the global level there is a well-grounded pluralist international society mainly motivated by coexistence, but with significant elements of cooperation around collective problems (e.g. arms control, environmental management) and projects (e.g. trade, big science). This world order is shaped by a more equitable global distribution of power, the availability of weapons of mass destruction, a powerful norm of anti-hegemony and the conspicuous and pressing presence of collective problems. This combination makes a more 'live and let live' mode of coexistence both possible and necessary. It embodies major structural differences from the 1930s that make the two cases not analogous. This world order without superpowers might be seen both as the successor to the unbalanced Western era of the 19th and 20th centuries, in which one civilization imposed itself massively on all of the others, and as the restoration of the classical order, in which the distribution of civilization and the distribution of power were fairly evenly matched and evenly distributed. The unique feature of this 'third way' is that for the first time it combines both a relatively even distribution of power worldwide and a densely integrated and interdependent global system and society. This might be labelled *decentred globalism* to contrast it with the centred globalism captured in the many core-periphery characterizations of the modern world order. It is a label that expresses the emergence of a truly post-colonial world order: a return to the more even distribution of power of pre-modern times, but in the globally integrated context created by modernity.

If *decentred globalism* is both plausible and possibly desirable, what are its prescriptive implications? The mainstream debates all seek to preserve some form of the Western status quo, a position I argue is historically, and perhaps morally, unsustainable. Hard realists believe that the US needs to defend its position against would-be superpower challengers. Believers in the 'power gap' think that the US should still use its power to reshape international society in line with its own values. Those of a more liberal disposition seek to find compromises in which a US-led liberal order is maintained in a less hegemonic and more institutional manner that accommodates rising powers. What policy prescriptions follow from the arguments in this article? By way of opening a debate on *decentred globalism*, I offer the following five thoughts:

1. There is no particular need for the US to see off challengers to its sole superpower status, first, because there are none, and, second, because that status is anyway indefensible both socially and materially.
2. After the collapse of communism and the fall of the Washington consensus everyone should feel ideologically both more open and more humble, and accept that what is needed is a period of competitive experimentation with the political economy of capitalism. Let the US continue its love affair with economic liberalism, Europe its with social liberalism, China and Russia theirs with authoritarian capitalism, and so on. Everyone should relax a bit, take a 'live and let live' attitude, and see how these different modes succeed or fail in producing the good life. Since no known alternative path to durable power exists, the general commitment to some form of capitalism is now quite deeply rooted.

3. All great powers need to look more to their regions and how to create stable, consensual and legitimate international societies there, and perhaps somewhat less to their relationships with each other. Traditional security concerns are no longer the key factor in relations amongst the great powers. China needs to think more about its relations with Japan and South-east Asia and less about those with the US, and the US needs to think more about its hemisphere and less about Asia and the Middle East. That is the decentring part of *decentred globalism*.
4. That said, all great powers also need to be aware of the substrate of ideas and institutions on which they agree, and to build on this to create not just a coexistence international society in which different modes of capitalism can live together peacefully, but also a cooperative one capable of handling joint projects such as world trade and big science, and collective action problems such as the environment and nuclear proliferation. Developing an interaction culture of friends and rivals is important.
5. The West as a whole, and the US in particular, need to accept the fact that they no longer own the future. They can take some satisfaction from having imposed much of their political, economic and social form onto the rest of the world, and so substantially shaped the direction in which the future will unfold. Now, however, they have to both acknowledge that not all of this was either good or well done, and let the rest of the world experiment on how best to accommodate its various cultural and historical characteristics to the Western legacy.

Notes

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